Arafat's speech to the United Nations 1974

Key question
What did Arafat achieve by speaking at the UN?

Key date
Arafat's speech to the UN: 1974

At the end of 1974, Yasser Arafat was invited to speak at the UN. He told his audience that the Palestinian problem was about a people without a home, a people who had been forced to flee from their homes and who were still, after 25 years, living in refugee camps. Many of his listeners at the UN were sympathetic. Some world leaders were beginning to admit that the Palestinians deserved a homeland. They also realised that if the Palestinians were granted their wish, then permanent peace in the Middle East was possible.

Arafat gave his speech with a holster attached to his hip although he left the gun outside the hall. He ended the speech with the words:

> Today I have come bearing an olive branch [a symbol of peace] and a freedom fighter's gun. Do not let the olive branch fall from my hand.

Although he received a sympathetic hearing at the UN, there was no breakthrough to peace. The Israelis were furious with the UN for inviting Arafat to speak. They said the PLO was a 'murder organisation'. They refused to discuss the idea of a separate Palestinian state, however small it might be. They feared that the Palestinians aimed to take back all of Israel and would not be content with a small state next door to Israel. The PLO was itself divided. Some extremists still insisted that Israel should be completely destroyed and taken over by Palestinians. They rejected the idea of a Palestinian 'mini-state' and did not want any Arab state to recognise Israel.

Apart from the treaty between Egypt and Israel in 1979 (see page 58), there was little sign of peace breaking out in the Middle East until the 1990s.

The USA pushes for peace

Key question
What impact did US diplomacy have on the PLO?

At the height of the *Intifada*, in December 1988, the USA opened secret talks with PLO officials. The Americans persuaded Yasser Arafat to do something he had never done before publicly: he rejected terrorism. He also spoke out in favour of a two-state solution to the Israeli–Palestinian conflict: an independent Palestinian state *alongside* Israel. In other words, he recognised the state of Israel. Now, at last, the USA was willing to negotiate openly with the PLO and to urge the Israelis to open peace talks with the Palestinians.

At first, the Israeli government was in no mood for compromise. They viewed Arafat's announcement as a 'propaganda exercise' and said that the PLO was still just a terrorist organisation. The Israeli Prime Minister said 'No' to withdrawal from the occupied territories, 'No' to recognition of the PLO, 'No' to a Palestinian state.